



Jargon Buster

Artifacts: Artifacts are distortions in an image that are produced by either the image sensor (CCD/CMOS), or the optical system. Sometimes the image processing algorithms and the compression algorithm (JPEG) are also responsible for Artifacts.

Digital zoom: Digital zoom is the magnification of an image by the internal image processing algorithm. It is similar to the zoom function in Adobe Photoshop. Due to the interpolation in real-time, digital zoom can appear to be jerky.

DPOF: Digital Print Order Format is a system format that allows a digital camera, or any other image capturing device, to define how images are to be printed on DPOF compatible printers.

View-finder: A view-finder is the window that you use to bring a subject into the frame. The types of view finders are Optical, EVF and the TTL. The Optical view-finder lets you view the subject through a small glass opening in the camera. An EVF (Electronic View Finder), simply projects a live image onto a small LCD screen, as would be seen on an LCD monitor. The TTL (Through The Lens) view-finders are the best, and are often seen on high-end digital cameras. The image is relayed from the lens through a mirror system directly onto a focus screen. TTL and EVF view-finders are more accurate because they are not affected by parallax errors.

Aperture priority: Aperture priority is a digital camera mode in which you set the aperture range, and the camera automatically adjusts the shutter speed to expose an image correctly. This is

useful to capture depth of field, or for special effects.

Shutter priority: In the Shutter priority mode, the shutter-speed of a camera is set to full range, and the camera calculates the best aperture to expose the image correctly. Shutter priority is used to creating blurry effects when you want to show a fast moving subject.

Manual focus: Manual focus allows you to disable the automatic focusing of the camera, and focus on the subject by moving the lens manually. Manual focus is used to take macro photographs, or when shooting in low-light conditions.

Macro: A macro is a magnified image of a small subject. Any image captured at a ratio higher than 1:1 is called a macro, whereas anything less than 1:2 is called a close-up.

ISO speeds: In film photography, the ISO value of a film represents the film's sensitivity. The lower the ISO speed, more the light required to create an image. In a digital camera, the CCD sensor takes care of this. A 200 ISO rated digital camera is recommended, as CCD is slower than film. Digital cameras also offer the advantage of on the fly ISO changing, but remember that higher ISO speeds tend to create noise in images.

Interpolation: Interpolation is an imaging method used to increase the size of a digital image. Digital cameras often use interpolation to produce digital zoom. Most image editing packages also support interpolation, to resize images. The trade off is the loss in image quality, which varies depending on the algorithm used.

Overall, the DC2300 from BenQ came out tops in the details test, with the Olympus C150 and Samsung Digimax 201 following with decent performances. The Logitech and the Vivicam 20 were major disappointments.

In the RGB target test, the Samsung Digimax 201 was the only camera that was able to realistically reproduce the RGB target, with only a slight deviation in the green spectrum, which, we found, was a tough spectrum to reproduce across the board. The BenQ DC2300 came in second, and the Olympus C150 Camedia came in third. The Creative PC-CAM 850 and the Frontech Regal CAM performed the worst—when we analysed the pictures, the RGB target contained more black than any other colour.

In the zoom test, the BenQ siblings and Olympus C150 were on par, taking the best looking close-up shots of the target, without loosing on either picture quality, or details. The Samsung Digimax 210 put up a brave fight, but lost on details. The Frontech Regal CAM, and Vivitar ViViCam 3625 were total disappointments, again.

And the winner is...

The market is flooded with these toycams, and their main appeal is their low prices. But, only after using these cameras in differ-

ent conditions does one realise that the images are not at par with the point-and-shoot film cameras.

We suggest you invest Rs 10,000 in the Samsung Digimax, and get a proper digital camera with a few manual override set-



The Digimax 201 hit the RGB right on the target



Opt for the Frontech Wonder CAM if you are committed to a small budget



tings and a digital zoom, rather than getting stuck with a glorified Web cameras that just don't deliver. The Benq DC2300 is another camera which will not disappoint—it offers decent image quality, colour reproduction and the flash also

helps. Logitech was a major disappointment, especially since it manufactures world-class input devices and Web cameras. The Frontech Wonder CAM was not impressive in the tests, but could be a popular choice for those with shoe string budgets, as it is priced at just Rs 6,500.

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